SOP-COM-001 · New to GitHub: your first hour

SOP COM-001 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-02 | For Every newcomer

Department: COM · **ID:** 001 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** the organisation's stewards · **Last changed:** 2026-11-02

Purpose

A person who has never used GitHub can, within one hour, have their own account, be inside the organisation, know five words, read the reading room in a browser, and bring an AI helper if they want one. Nothing in this hour asks them to type a command.

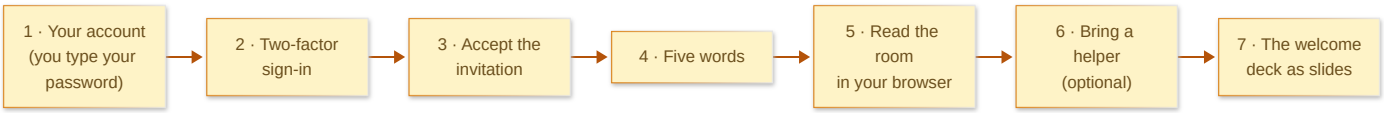
Scope

Every newcomer to any of the organisation's GitHub spaces: members, board members, volunteers, partners. It ends where SOP-IT-002 (helper access in depth) and SOP-GOV-002 (how collaboration works) begin.

Roles

Role	Does
Newcomer	creates their own account, types their own password, accepts, reads
Steward	sends the invitation and the links, answers questions, never asks for a password
Helper (optional)	reads alongside the newcomer, explains, never receives a password or a code

The hour at a glance



Prerequisites

An email address you read, a phone (for two-factor sign-in), a browser. The steward has your email address or will send you a link once you have an account.

Steps

1 · Your account (about 10 minutes)

1. Go to `https://github.com/signup` and enter **your own** email address. *You should see:* a page asking for a password.
2. **Type your own password.** Nobody else types it, sees it or keeps it: not a steward, not a friend, not an AI helper. A password manager may suggest one. *You should see:* a username field.
3. Choose a username. It is public and lasts; your first name and something you like works. *You should see:* GitHub's puzzle or email code.
4. Confirm the code from your email, choose the **Free** plan. *You should see:* your empty dashboard, your picture (a pattern for now) top right.
5. Send your **username** (never the password) to the steward where you already talk.

> ***Important.*** *If anyone, a person or a helper, ever asks for your password or a sign-in code, the answer is no. A steward never needs them: invitations go to your username.*

2 · Two-factor sign-in (about 10 minutes)

1. Picture (top right) → **Settings** → **Password and authentication** → **Enable two-factor authentication**. *You should see:* a QR code.
2. Scan it with an authenticator app (or use a passkey or SMS, if offered), type the six digits. *You should see:* a list of **recovery codes**.
3. **Download the recovery codes and keep them where you keep important papers.** They are the only way back in if the phone is lost. Never paste them anywhere. *You should see:* "Two-factor authentication is enabled".

Organisations in this fleet require two-factor sign-in; the invitation waits until it is on.

3 · Accept the invitation (2 minutes)

1. Open the email titled *"… invited you to join the … organization"*, or the bell icon on GitHub. *You should see:* a green **Join** button.
2. Click **Join**. *You should see:* the organisation's page; its name under your profile's **Organizations**.
3. If you were also added to a team (for example **readers**), GitHub may ask you to accept that too.

4 · Five words (5 minutes)

Word	Means	Where you see it
Repository	a folder that remembers every change and who made it	every link that looks like `github.com/theholyearthfoundation/<name>`
Branch	one line of that history; `main` is the live copy, `preview` the rehearsal	the branch picker above the file list
Pull request	a change asking to move from one branch to another, with a place to comment	the **Pull requests** tab
Issue	a conversation thread: the easiest way to ask or answer	the **Issues** tab
Merge	accepting a pull request, so the change lands; a person with the role does it	the green button at the foot of a pull request

That is all the vocabulary this hour needs. SOP-GOV-002 has the rest when you want it.

5 · Read the room in your browser (15 minutes)

1. Open the reading room link the steward sent (`https://github.com/theholyearthfoundation/reading-room`) while signed in. *You should see:* its README, an index of what to read first.
2. Click **000 Start here** (or the first link in the index). *You should see:* a page with a TL;DR at the top.
3. For a printable copy, open the `pdf/` folder beside it and click the PDF. *You should see:* the same page as a document.
4. **A 404 means "no permission yet"**, not "broken": check you are signed in as the account you sent the steward, and tell them the link.
5. Visitors (and you, signed out) can see the public room: `https://theholyearthfoundation.github.io/reading-room-public/` .

6 · Bring a helper (optional, 10 minutes)

1. Choose a helper you already use (Claude, ChatGPT, Codex, Littlebird, any of them).
2. Ask it to **read with you, not for you**: paste the page's text, or give it the link if it is already connected to GitHub with your permission.
3. A good first question: *"Read 000 Start here and tell me, in five lines, what is waiting for my answer."*
4. **Never give a helper your password, a sign-in code or a recovery code.** If it needs its own access to private pages, follow SOP-IT-002 (a read-only key in your own account, or an approved connection).

7 · The welcome deck as slides (5 minutes)

1. Open the organisation's public profile: `https://github.com/theholyearthfoundation`. *You should see:* a banner and a **Welcome deck** link.
2. Click it. The deck is in `.github/decks/` as a PDF (slides you page through), an HTML page and the markdown it was made from. *You should see:* the first slide, *Welcome to …*.
3. Page through it once. It walks the same road as this hour and points at the real pages.

Later, on a Mac: hidden files

This isn't part of the hour. It's for the day you keep a copy of a repository on your own computer and copy a folder.

- **In Finder, ⌘⇧. (Command, Shift, full stop) shows hidden files.** Press it again to hide them. Names that start with a dot are normally hidden, among them `.git`, which holds the folder's whole history and the address it pushes to.
- **Copying a folder copies its `.git`, address included.** Rename the copy, swap everything inside, and it still pushes to the original.
- **After any copy, check where it pushes:** open Terminal, go into the copy (`cd`), and run `git remote -v`. *You should see:* two lines with the address of the repository this copy belongs to. If the organisation's name is wrong, don't push.

A worked example. Two organisations each keep their logos in a `brand-assets` repository. You copy Organisation A's folder to start Organisation B's, and swap in B's logos. The copy's `.git` still says A, so `git push` from there puts B's logos into A's repository, and if A's is public, in front of everyone. Nothing warns you: to git it's an ordinary push.

If the copy is the start of something new, drag its `.git` to the Trash and start with `git init`. Changing only the address would carry the old history along. The full walkthrough is `my-template/walkthroughs/SHOW-HIDDEN-FILES.md`.

Verification

The newcomer: has two-factor sign-in on; sees the organisation under **Organizations**; opened the reading room's README and one PDF from their own account; can say the five words in their own words. The steward: sees them as a member (and in the readers team) on the organisation's **People** page.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
No invitation email	sent to another address, or two-factor not yet on	check the bell icon on GitHub; turn on two-factor; ask the steward to resend to your username
The reading room shows 404	signed out, signed in as another account, or the team not yet accepted	sign in; accept the team; tell the steward the link and your username
"Your organization requires two-factor authentication"	step 2 not done	do step 2, then accept again
Lost phone	the authenticator is gone	sign in with a recovery code, then set up two-factor again
A helper asks for your password	it should not	say no; follow step 6 or SOP-IT-002
You copied a folder and aren't sure where it pushes	a copied folder keeps its `.git`, address included	run `git remote -v` in the copy; see *Later, on a Mac: hidden files*

Related

- SOP-GOV-002 *GitHub collaboration* (organisations, teams, issues, pull requests, Pages)
- SOP-IT-002 *Reading room and helper access* (a helper's own key, in depth)
- SOP-OPS-001 *How a change travels* (what `preview` and `main` mean in practice)
- `my-template/walkthroughs/JOIN-AN-ORGANIZATION.md`, `my-template/decks-template/` (the welcome deck)
- `my-template/walkthroughs/SHOW-HIDDEN-FILES.md` (hidden files and copied folders), `my-template/walkthroughs/OPENING-YOUR-GIFT.md` (for someone who has never heard of GitHub)

Change log

Date	Change	By
2026-11-01	Drafted for every organisation in the fleet: account (your own password), two-factor, invitation, five words, the reading room in a browser, a helper, the welcome deck	Alfred
2026-11-01	Adopted for The Holy Earth Foundation from the shared template: amber badges and icons, the foundation's login filled in where a page names a real address	Alfred
2026-11-02	*Later, on a Mac: hidden files*: ⌘⇧. shows `.git`, copying a folder copies where it pushes, check with `git remote -v`	Alfred

Part of the fleet's procedures. The master copies and the legend live in my-template.